

Spam Magnets

Dear Asha,
I no longer complain that nobody sends me e-mail. Ever since you showed me how to use the Internet, I've posted my e-mail address at various newsgroups and forums. Also, I've signed up with Hotmail, Yahoo! and many others, and have chosen the option to make my e-mail address public. There are so many other sites on the Internet that require me to sign up—they are so nice, not only do they send me regular news about themselves, but also hand out my e-mail address to others.

Now I get so much e-mail everyday, it takes me around three hours just going

through all of them. The Internet has really helped to get me recognised. There are several large companies offering me jobs from home. They say others who have worked with them have made millions of dollars! And then there is this poor leper who has been rejected by society. There's no one to help him. I sent him Rs 500 yesterday.

The Internet is a great window of opportunity for all of us. In fact, I'm going to put up your address too, at all the sites I visit.

Cheers and take care!

Bhola



RBL and matches headers in the reported spam against this. Also, if it detects the URL of a site several times in the message body, it considers that as advertisement and classifies the mail as spam. Once identified as spam, it sends a report to the administrator of the originating address, with guides to a few possible actions that he can take. Reported sites are not necessarily added to the Blocking List—this depends on the nature of the spam, the quantity and frequency of reports against the site and other such factors.

In most cases, the identified spammer is just an innocent bystander. Professional bulk mailers look out for open servers from where they can freely send mail. For example, VSNL users may remember that earlier anyone could send e-mail using any of the VSNL SMTP servers. Later, they closed open relay and allowed mail to be sent only from an authorised VSNL connection. In fact, professional bulk mailers maintain entire lists of such networks so that they can jump from one to another when one implements tighter security features or to avoid anti-spam organisations. Thus, anti-spam organisations have also started maintaining lists of open-relay

etc. For example, on a bad day, the Beijing Express E-mail Address Extractor (www.zstools.com) harvests over a thousand addresses in just 15 minutes!

Now spam-haters and anti-spam organisations have launched a new battle against bulk mailers capture the spam before it reaches the user. Pseudo-intelligent filters are set up on the server itself, which simply gobble up what they think is spam. This way, the user forgoes the daily irritation and does not encourage spammers.

The weaponry

Several ways of identifying and blocking spam have evolved with the new spamming techniques—all of them based on rules determined by the developers of anti-spam software, and logic, which are updated according to the practices of spammers. How aggressive the preventive measures are depends on these rules and also on what the software does with spam—whether it simply deletes the mail, or notifies the sender and intended recipient or moves it to a separate folder for the recipient's scrutiny.

Four years ago, Microsoft tried to block unwanted e-mail by filtering out incoming messages from Outlook 98 that contained certain text, such as a string of exclamation marks or the phrase 'for free'.

Today, spam blockers are getting more intelligent. Hotmail has signed up with Mail Abuse Prevention System (MAPS, www.mail-abuse.org), an organisation formed to crack down on spam, which maintains a Realtime Blackhole List (RBL). This list contains details of sites and ISPs that support sites that send out spam. Any mail coming in to a Hotmail

mailbox is analysed against this list and if the addresses match any of the spammers, it is identified as spam, and sent to the Junk Mail folder. Lately, Hotmail has been applying the filter to outgoing mail too.

Hotmail has been handling spam with an iron hand. It simply blocks out mail from and to certain ISPs and several users are now realising that they have been losing important mail. For example, the US-

“ If Microsoft, one of the largest technology companies, can say who we send e-mail to, that really puts constraints on freedom of ”

— Ben Johnson, a frustrated Hotmail user who lost many important messages

based ISP Media3 Technologies is listed on the RBL because it hosts half a dozen spammers. However, it also hosts sites such as Peacefire.org, which recently alerted its members that Hotmail users have been unable to reach them for five months! On the other hand, many users are happy because the spam to their inbox has been drastically cut down since Hotmail adopted spam filters.

SpamCop (www.spamcop.net) is a free service for blocking spam, which uses several kinds of logic to identify spam. Anyone can sign up with SpamCop and members can report any mail they receive as spam, as per the guidelines on the site. The mail is read by an automatic parser on the site that checks whether the mail actually seems like spam. SpamCop maintains a Blocking List similar to the

servers—ones that allow anyone to send mail from their networks. These usually end up being the innocent bystanders.

Apart from just reporting e-mail abuse, ISPs and administrators can also configure their mail servers to link up to the SpamCop Blocking List and have all mail screened against the SpamCop systems, thus reducing the amount of spam on their networks. This again is similar to the idea of MAPS—to capture spam at the source to avoid encouraging spammers.

Spamhaus.org maintains the Spamhaus Block List (SBL)—a list of verified spammers, spam gangs and spam support services. The Register of Known Spam Operations (ROSKO, www.spamhaus.org) is maintained by Steve Linford, who estimates that about 90 per cent of all the spam is from just a hundred-odd large spam organisations. This list is intended to help cut down spam drastically. Linford also suggests that shutting down sites that

info A study by Jupiter Media Metrix predicts that by 2006, an average user will receive nearly 1,500 unsolicited e-mails annually